

Lesson 5: “This is the Spirit of Revelation” (D&C 6, 8, 9; Joseph Smith—History 1:8-17)

Purpose: To help us understand how to prepare to receive personal revelation and encourage us to do so.

1. Our need for personal revelation.

†1. “Revelation” Bible Dictionary

†2. Elder Boyd K. Packer

Why do you think personal revelation is so important in our day?

What are some decisions or situations in which personal revelation can help us?

2. Understanding what we should do to receive revelation.

How then, from the scriptures, can we learn to prepare to receive personal revelation?

A. D&C 9:8; JS—History 1:8-10. ([Study the matter in your mind.](#))

What can we do to study out a question in our own minds?

What do you think are some key phrases from verse eight of both of these scriptures?

- “Joseph Smith gave deep thought to settling the question of which church was right. He also invested much time and effort, attending meetings, studying the scriptures, and searching longer than two years for an answer.” (*L. M.*)

Why does the Lord expect us to study matters out in our own minds before receiving revelation?

How has studying matters out in your own mind helped you grow spiritually?

B. Joseph Smith—History 1:11-12; D&C 138:1-11.

([Ponder and meditate upon the scriptures and the teachings of latter-day prophets.](#))

Why is it important to study and ponder the scriptures when we seek revelation?

How has scripture study helped you when you have sought revelation from the Lord?

†3. Elder Dallin H. Oaks

C. D&C 6:5, 14; 8:1; 42:61; 88:63-64.

([Inquire of the Lord in faith, with an honest heart, believing you will receive.](#))

- “No message appears in scripture more times, in more ways than ‘Ask, and ye shall receive’” (Elder Boyd K. Packer, “[Reverence Invites Revelation](#),” *Ensign*, Nov. 1991, 23). “Most of the revelations in the Doctrine and Covenants are answers to questions that the Prophet Joseph Smith asked the Lord.” (*Lesson Manual*)

What does it mean to “ask in faith”? (See D&C 8:1; 1 Nephi 15:11; Moroni 10:4) †4. Pres. Spencer Kimball

What does it mean to ask “with an honest heart”? (D&C 8:1)

- a. We honestly seek to understand the Lord's will and ask only for those things that accord with it.
- b. We ensure that our motives for asking are pure.
- c. We are repentant.

- JS—History 1:13-16 What can we learn about prayer from this passage? ([e.g. praying vocally, etc.](#))

- D&C 6:14; 42:61 What does the Lord promise as we ask in faith, with an honest heart?

How have these promises been fulfilled in your life?

D. D&C 63:23; 76:5-10; 93:1, 28; 101:7-8. ([Be obedient and serve God.](#))

Why is obedience needed as we seek revelation? †5. Elder Dallin H. Oaks

E. D&C 5:23-24; 112:10; 136:32-33; Ether 12:27; Moroni 7:43-44; 2 Nephi 9:42 ([Be meek and humble.](#))

Why is humility important as we seek revelation from God? †6. David Whitmer recalled

F. D&C 25:10; 30:2. ([Focus on the things of God rather than the things of the world.](#))

Why is it important to focus on “the things of [God]” rather than “things of the earth” as we seek revelation?

†7. Elder Boyd K. Packer

†8. Elder Neal A. Maxwell

([Doctrine and Covenants Manual: Religion 324 and 325](#)). (You can download a free PDF manual.)

Next Week: Lesson 4: “Remember the New Covenant, ... the Book of Mormon; See [L4 Study Guide](#).

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†1. **“Revelation” Bible Dictionary:** “Divine revelation is one of the grandest concepts and principles of the gospel of Jesus Christ, for without it, man could not know of the things of God.... Continuous revelation from God to his saints ... makes possible daily guidance along true paths and leads the faithful soul to complete and eternal salvation in the celestial kingdom.... Without revelation, all would be guesswork, darkness, and confusion” (Bible Dictionary, “[Revelation](#),” 762)

†2. **Elder Boyd K. Packer:** “No one of us can survive in the world of today, much less in what it soon will become, without personal inspiration” (“[Reverence Invites Revelation](#),” *Ensign*, Nov. 1991, 23).

†3. **Elder Dallin H. Oaks:** “Scripture reading may ... lead to current revelation on whatever [subject] the Lord wishes to communicate to the reader at that time. We do not overstate the point when we say that the scriptures can be a Urim and Thummim to assist each of us to receive personal revelation.

“Because we believe that scripture reading can help us receive revelation, we are encouraged to read the scriptures again and again. By this means, we obtain access to what our Heavenly Father would have us know and do in our personal lives today. That is one reason Latter-day Saints believe in *daily* scripture study” (“[Scripture Reading and Revelation](#),” *Ensign*, Jan. 1995, 8).

†4. **President Spencer W. Kimball:** “Do you offer a few trite words and worn-out phrases, or do you talk intimately to the Lord? Do you pray occasionally when you should be praying regularly, often, constantly? ... When you pray, do you just peak, or do you also listen? ... Do you give thanks or merely ask for favors?” (“[Prayer](#),” *New Era*, Mar. 1978, 17).

†5. **Elder Dallin H. Oaks taught,** “The way to revelation is righteousness” (*The Lord’s Way* [1991], 34). He also taught “We cannot have the companionship of the Holy Ghost—the medium of individual revelation—if we are in transgression or if we are angry or if we are in rebellion against God’s chosen authorities” (“[Teaching and Learning by the Spirit](#),” *Ensign*, Mar. 1997, 9).

†6. **David Whitmer recalled** that one morning when Joseph Smith was getting ready to resume translating the Book of Mormon, “something went wrong about the house and he was put out about it. Something that Emma, his wife, had done. Oliver and I went upstairs and Joseph came up soon after to continue the translation but he could not do anything. He could not translate a single syllable. He went downstairs, out into

the orchard, and made supplication to the Lord; was gone about an hour—came back to the house, and asked Emma’s forgiveness and then came upstairs where we were and then the translation went on all right. He could do nothing save he was humble and faithful” (quoted in B. H. Roberts, *A Comprehensive History of the Church*, 1:131).

†7. **Elder Boyd K. Packer:** “Inspiration comes more easily in peaceful settings. Such words as *quiet*, *still*, *peaceable*, *Comforter* abound in the scriptures...

“The world grows increasingly noisy. Clothing and grooming and conduct are looser and sloppier and more disheveled. Raucous music, with obscene lyrics blasted through amplifiers while lights flash psychedelic colors, characterizes the drug culture. Variations of these things are gaining wide acceptance and influence over our youth...

“This trend to more noise, more excitement, more contention, less restraint, less dignity, less formality is not coincidental nor innocent nor harmless.

“The first order issued by a commander mount a military invasion is the jamming of the channels of communication of those he intends to conquer.

“Irreverence suits the purposes of the adversary by obstructing the delicate channels of revelation in both mind and spirit” (“[Reverence Invites Revelation](#),” *Ensign*, Nov. 1991, 23).

†8. **Elder Neal A. Maxwell:** “Divine guidance is so crucial ... that we need to go out of our way to put ourselves in a situation in which such special help can be given. President David O. McKay spoke of how the morning hours, before we are cluttered with the cares of day, are especially conducive to inspiration. Others have felt that solitude and reading the scriptures can create an atmosphere conducive to the Spirit and can be developed. After all, to read the words of Christ already before us is a good thing to do before asking for more” (*Wherefore, Ye Must Press Forward* [1977], 121).

Recommended Reading:

Elder Boyd K. Packer, “[Reverence Invites Revelation](#),” *Ensign*, Nov. 1991, 23.

Elder Dallin H. Oaks, “[Scripture Reading and Revelation](#),” *Ensign*, Jan. 1995, 8.

President Spencer W. Kimball, (“[Prayer](#),” *New Era*, Mar. 1978, 17.

Elder Dallin H. Oaks, “[Teaching and Learning by the Spirit](#),” *Ensign*, Mar. 1997, 9.

Visit www.stephenmbird.com/library/gospel-doctrine †

Further Enrichment Resources:

Receiving Revelation

Joseph Smith: “A person may profit by noticing the first intimation of the spirit of revelation; for instance, when you feel pure intelligence flowing into you, **it may give you sudden strokes of ideas**, so that **by noticing it, you may find it fulfilled the same day or soon** ... thus by *learning* the Spirit of God and understanding it, you may grow into *the principle of revelation*, until you become perfect in Christ Jesus.” (HC 3:381. Italics added.) (Cited by Joseph Fielding McConkie, *Seeking the Spirit*, (Salt Lake City, Utah: Deseret Book Company, 1978)

Ted Gibbons: “If you want **to uncover the truth**, you will need a S.P.A.D.E.

S = Study:

Notice how the following words from Joseph’s account of the first vision (Joseph Smith—History) indicate his efforts to learn the truth by study.

- “I attended their several meetings” (1:8)
- “I was unable to come to any certain conclusion” (1:8)
- “I was one day reading the epistle of James” (1:11)
- “I reflected on it again and again”) 1:12)
- “At length I came to the conclusion” (1:13)

P = Ponder:

- “My mind was called up to serious reflection” (1:8)
- “I often said to myself: What is to be done” (1:10)
- “Who of all these parties is right?” (1:10)
- “It was impossible ... to come to any certain conclusion” (1:8)

A = Alone:

- “I retired to the woods” (1:14)
- “... finding myself alone” (1:15)

The instruction to seek the Lord in a place free from distractions has been given often. See Alma 34:26-27; Matt. 14:23; Matt. 6:6; Alma 33:7.

D = Desires:

- “I kneeled down and began to offer up the desires of my heart to God” (1:15)

In the area of desires, see 3 Ne. 19:24; 1 Ne. 2:16; Enos 1:12; Ether 3:2.

E = Exertion

- “But exerting all my powers to call upon God” (1:16)
 - “Just at this moment of greatest alarm” (1:16)”
- ([Ted L. Gibbons](#), DCL3 “I Had Seen A Vision”)

DC Student Manual, Religion 324 and 325:

D&C 6:1-9. Repetitions in the Doctrine & Covenants

“**Section 6 verses 1-9** are identical to **section 11** verses 1-9. **Verses 1-5** are identical to **section 12** verses 1-5 and **section 14** verses 1-5. The message in these verses is of universal importance to all Saints—indeed, the Lord has said, “**What I say unto one I say unto all**” (D&C 61:18, 36; 82:; 92:1; 93:49). The repetition stresses that great importance.” (Page 15)

D&C 6:2. “Quick and Powerful. Sharper Than a Two-edged Sword”

“The word *quick* in the King James Version of the Bible does not mean swift but rather “**living, alive**” (Bible Dictionary, “quick,” p. 756). To be quickened by the Spirit means to be given spiritual life. The word of the Lord is quick and powerful because it is a source of life, energy, and power.

“Many swords of ancient times had only one cutting edge. When someone decided to make a two-edged sword, the effectiveness of the weapon was increased tremendously. Now it could cut in any direction, no matter how the blow was struck. Thus, the likening of the word of God to the two-edged sword is a vivid simile. Just as a sharp sword can cut deep enough to sever limbs and destroy life, so the word of the Lord is powerful enough that it can bring destruction of the soul (spiritual death) to those who do not give heed to it (see Hebrews 4:12; Revelation 1:16; 2:12, 16). The word of God also has power to pierce the soul as a sword and penetrate to the innermost parts of man (see 3 Nephi 11:3; D&C 85:6). It can cut through error and falsehood with double-edged efficiency.” (Page 15)

Did You Think to Pray? (Hymn 140)

Ere you left your room this morning.
Did you think to pray?
In the name of Christ, our Savior,
Did you sue for loving favor
As a shield today?

CHORUS:

Oh, how praying rests the weary!
Prayer will change the night to day.
So, when life gets dark and dreary,
Don’t forget to pray.

When your heart was filled with anger,
Did you think to pray?
Did you plead for grace, my brother,
That you might forgive another
Who had crossed your way?

When sore trials came upon you,
Did you think to pray?
When your soul was full of sorrow,
Balm of Gilead did you borrow
At the gates of day.